

Sports, Culture, and Society

CORE 2500-22

(Will count for CAL 2100 / ANTH 2120, which is a required course for the Sports & Society Minor)

Fall 2026, TR 1:15-2:30, Garland

Instructor	Contact	Office Hours
Prof. Gabriel A. Torres Colón	g.torres@vanderbilt.edu	After class, Cammack Family Gallery; and Garland 207, by appointment

TEACHING ASSISTANTS

Rosseirys N. “Ro” De La Rosa, Ava Nesmith, Joy Moorer

COURSE DESCRIPTION AND LEARNING OBJECTIVES

This course introduces students to *anthropological and interdisciplinary* approaches to studying sports, culture, and society. This course also introduces theories of *embodiment*, which we can use to understand the *intertwining of biology, culture, and experience*. We first review the evolutionary, prehistoric, and historical foundations of sport in play and ritual. Drawing on examples from the U.S. and around the world, most of the course explores how contemporary sports—from everyday practices to highly ritualized events—are entangled with broader social and cultural phenomena like gender, race, class, and nationality.

Through the semester, we will engage with ethical questions of character development, virtues, and social responsibility. Sports can enrich or stifle individuals. Similarly, sports can serve to oppress or liberate social groups. As such, we will reflect on how sports can help us better understand humanity and social problems.

By the end of the semester, students should be able to: (1) explain the evolutionary, prehistoric, and historical foundations of sporting practices; (2) analyze how cultural notions of gender, race, and nationalism are reified and challenged through sporting practices; (3) formulate critiques of how sports are embodied as a result of historical, political, and economic processes; (4) analyze contemporary sports social issues using fundamental anthropological and interdisciplinary concepts and theories; and (5) habitually reflect on how character and virtues can be enriched through the study of sports, culture, and society.

As an exploratory core course, we will build the capacities (B) systematic and structural thinking and (C) cultural and interpretative investigation. We will develop systematic and structural thinking by understanding the multiple, complex ways sports are intertwined with cultural and social systems, past and present. We will achieve cultural and interpretative investigation by studying how gender, race, and other forms of social difference shape our experiences of sport.

REQUIRED READINGS

- Fitzgerald, Matt (2020) [Comeback Quotient](#)
- All other readings are posted on Brightspace in the Content section.

COURSEWORK AND ASSESSMENT

- Current Events and Media Assignments: You must regularly engage with current events in the sporting world. Therefore, you should make a habit of reading/watching sports news from *various* news sources. The library gives you free access to the *NY Times*, which gives you access to *The Athletic*. In addition, we will occasionally assign media clips for you to watch alongside readings or as a class assignment. These media assignments are not on the syllabus, but they are required. We will email you and post these media assignments on Brightspace.
- Quizzes: You will have eight quizzes throughout the semester that assess reading comprehension and fundamental concepts from lectures. These quizzes will be comprised of objective questions. The best way to prepare for quizzes is to (1) make sure you have a solid grasp of the main arguments presented in the readings due on the due date of the quiz and (2) review the lecture slides from the class preceding the quiz to make sure you grasp the concepts and arguments presented with each slide. Quizzes are worth 10 points. If you miss points on the quizzes, you will be able

to make them up through extra credit assignments throughout the semester.

- Reflections: There will be fourteen reflections throughout the semester to assess your engagement with sports, society, culture, and character. Attention! All reflections will be self-assessed. This does not mean that we will be disengaged with your writing. It means we want you to take control of your education and not let concern over grades compromise your love for learning. Every reflection will have a rubric that you will use to assess yourself. Except for the final reflection, which is worth 20 points, each reflection is worth 10 points. We will monitor self-assessment for those who choose to abuse the system by giving themselves good grades without doing the work. Blatant abuse of self-assessment will be considered the same as cheating. You are not allowed to use AI in any capacity for your reflections.
- Grades will be calculated by converting the total number of points into a 0 to 100 scale: 96-100 = A, 90-95.9 = A-, 86-89.9 = B+, 83-85.9 = B, 80-82.9 = B-, 76-79.9 = C+, 73-75.9 = C, 70-72.9 = C-, 60-69.9 = D, 0-59.9 = F

LATE ASSIGNMENT POLICY

Reflections turned in late without a valid excuse will be automatically deducted one letter grade after one day (10%), two letter grades after the second day (20%), and so on. If you are having problems finishing an assignment, you must come to see us before the assignment's due date. Quizzes not completed by the due date before class will receive a 0. All assignments are due before class begins.

DISABILITIES

We subscribe to the following statements, which have been written by Vanderbilt administrators for faculty use: "This class respects and welcomes students of all backgrounds, identities, and abilities. If circumstances make our learning environment and activities difficult, if you have medical information you need to share with me, or if you need specific arrangements in case the building needs to be evacuated, please let me know. I am committed to creating an effective learning environment for all students, but I can only do so if you discuss your needs with me as early as possible. I promise to keep these discussions confidential. If appropriate, also contact the Vanderbilt Equal Opportunity, Affirmative Action, and Disability Services Department (EAD) to get more information about specific accommodations."

CLASS CANCELLATIONS

If we cannot make it to class or run late, we will notify you via email and Brightspace.

CELLPHONES/LAPTOPS

This is mostly a tech-free class. Please put cell phones and computers away during class time. Still, you should have an electronic device with access to Brightspace (preferably a laptop) in your bag and ready to use for a few class exercises. If you have accommodations for notetaking on a computer, please come see me on the first day of class. Do not send text messages or chat online during class.

RECORDING DURING CLASS

The use of technologies for audio and video recording of lectures and other classroom activities is not allowed in this class unless you have the express permission of the primary instructor. When students have permission for personal use of recordings, they must still obtain written permission from the instructor to share recordings with others. For students registered with the Office of Student Access Services and approved for audio and/or video recording of lectures and other classroom activities as a reasonable accommodation, applicable federal law requires instructors to permit those recordings. Such recordings are also limited to personal use, except with the instructor's written permission and the permission of other students in the class.

ATTENDANCE

Your presence is essential to do well in this course, and we expect students to attend every class. Please note that whether present or not, you will be responsible for all materials covered that day. There will be a sign-in sheet for each table that you must sign at the beginning of every class. Attendance will sometimes be taken via Brightspace in a non-graded quiz. *After two unexcused absences, students will lose 10% of their final grade for each additional missed class.*

*** I reserve the right to make changes to the syllabus throughout the semester. However, I promise that these changes will not affect you adversely. I will announce syllabus changes in class and post the updated syllabus on Brightspace.**

COURSE ORGANIZATION, READINGS, AND ASSIGNMENTS

WEEK 1: WHY STUDY SPORTS, CULTURE, AND SOCIETY?

Thu (8/27) Introductions and Course Overview

WEEK 2: EVOLUTION, PLAY, AND HUMAN DEVELOPMENT

Tue (9/1) We Play Like Apes, We Play Like Our Ancestors
Due: **Reading:** Fox – Prologue and Chapter 1 (Brightspace)

Thu (9/3) From Child Play to Sport: What Do We Lose, What Do We Gain?
Due: **Reading:** Konner: “Play, Social Learning, and Teaching” (Brightspace)
Reflection #1: Should Play be More Serious?

WEEK 3: BIOCULTURAL APPROACHES TO ATHLETICISM AND HUMAN DIVERSITY

Tue (9/8) Evolutionary Foundations of Human Movement
Due: **Reading:** Ocobock and Lacy, “Woman the Hunter” (Brightspace)
Quiz #1

Thu (9/10) Genes, Trainability, and Human Biological Diversity
Due: **Reading:** Epstein – Chapters 1, 2, and 3 (Brightspace)
Reflection #2: Habituation through practice: Are elite athletes super-humans?

WEEK 4: RACE AND CROSS-CULTURAL APPROACHES TO SPORT

Tue (9/15) The (Un)Science of Race
Due: ***Reading:** Epstein – Chapters 9, 10, and 11
***Quiz #2**

Thu (9/17) The Many Cultural Functions of Sports in Society
Due: **Reading:** Fox – Chapters 2 and 4 (Brightspace)
Reflection #3: How do sports reflect cultural norms and ideals?

WEEK 5: IDENTITY AND POWER

Tue (9/22) The Political Economy of Difference
Due: **Reading:** Foer – “How Soccer Explains the Pornography of Sects”
Quiz #3

Thu (9/24) Guest Speaker, Dr. Celso Castilho
Due: **Reading:** Castilho – “The 2026 World Cup, ICE, and Long Shadow of USA ‘94”
Reflection #4: How can sports nourish the virtue of transcendence?

WEEK 6: GLOBAL PERSPECTIVES

Tue (9/29) World Systems
Due: **Reading:** Besnier, Brownell, and Carter – “Sports Colonialism, and Imperialism”
Quiz #4

Thu (10/1) Post-Colonialism
Due: **Reading:** Uperesa, “Fabled Futures”
Reflection #5: Perspective of and responsibility for structural inequality?

WEEK 7: DOING SPORTS ETHNOGRAPHY

- Tue (10/6)** Magic
Due: **Read:** Gmelch – “Baseball Magic”
Watch: “Why Baseball Players Are So Superstitious”
- Thu (10/8)** Performance
Due: **Reading:** Besnier, Brownell, and Carter – “Sport, Cultural Performance, and Mega-Events”
Reflection #6: TBA

WEEK 8: HOPE

- Tue (10/13)** Meaningful Play and the Political Economy of Hope
Due: **Reading:** Torres Colón – Fighting for Family and Glory
Reflection #7: What is caring and how can we care?
- Thu (10/15)** Guest Speaker, Eva Jones Young
Due: **Reading:** Jones Young Life Stories
Quiz #5

WEEK 9: CARE

- Tue (10/20)** Problems and Methods
Due: **Reading:** Canada, Introduction and Chapter 1
Quiz #6
- Thu (10/22)** ~No Class, Fall Break~

WEEK 10: EMBODIMENT

- Tue (10/27)** Social Embodiments
Due: **Reading:** Canada, Chapters 2 and 3
Quiz #7
- Thu (10/29)** Styles
Due: **Reading:** Torres – “To Be Like the Greatest”
Reflection #8: TBA

WEEK 11: FAIRNESS / RESPONSIBILITY

- Tue (11/3).** Gender and Fairness, In Sport and Life
Due: **Reading:** Fitzgerald, Preface and Chapters 1 and 2
- Thu (11/5)** Virtues
Due: **Reading:** Fitzgerald, Chapters 3 and 4
Reflection #9: Care, Accepting, and Embracing

WEEK 12: CHARACTERS AND VIRTUES

- Tue (11/10)** Ultrarealism
Due: **Reading:** Fitzgerald, Chapter 5
Quiz #8
- Thu (11/12)** Comebacks
Due: **Reading:** Fitzgerald, Chapters 6, 7, 8, and 9
Reflection #10: Addressing Reality

WEEK 13: LANGUAGE AND COMMUNICATION

- Tue (11/17)** Sociolinguistics of Sports
- Thu (11/19)** Coaching Language
Due: **Reading:** TBA
***Reflection #11: Inspiration**

~~Thanksgiving Break~~

WEEK 14: PAIN AND BODY MODIFICATION

- Tue (12/1)** Enhancement
Due: **Reading:** Ventresca and Brady – “Food for Thought;” Denham – When Science, Politics, and Policy Collide
Reflection #12: How can increased perspective alter our judgments? Can kindness transform our sense of fairness?
- Thu (12/3)** Flex / TBA

WEEK 15: FRIENDSHIP AND FAMILY

- Tue (12/8)** Sports Talk and Sociality
Reading: Reed – Social Media is Dropping the Ball
Reflection #13: Can humility in sports talk sell?
- Thu (12/10)** Guest Speaker, David Friend

FINALS WEEK

Final Reflection: Ultrarealism and Human Flourishment